Till mid-1961, so long as Thimayya and Thorat remained at the helm of the Indian Army and Eastern Command respectively, there was still some semblance of sense in the tactical deployment of the army. Thorat, for example, was not willing to commit his defensive line beyond Bomdila, adhering to the theory that should China attack, the logistical problem of the southern slopes would be 'his rather than ours'. But all this was simply marking time; in April 1961, with Thimayya retiring, out went Lieutenant General S. P. P. Thorat and Lieutenant General S. D. Verma, both resigning within hours of the new structure being announced. As we know, Pran Thapar was the new COAS while Bijji Kaul was to be the CGS. Bogey Sen moved to Eastern Command while Lieutenant General Daulet Singh took over the reins of Western Command.

The new Western Army Commander, like Bijji Kaul, carried the same chip of not having any real combat experience. He was an armoured corps officer who had commanded a squadron of 18 Cavalry. After heading the Armament Group in the Armoured Corps Centre and School in Ahmadnagar, he had commanded the 2nd Independent Armoured Brigade after which he was given charge of the 1st Armoured Division. After the command of a corps, Daulet Singh was entrusted with the command of the Western Army that at the time was headquartered in Simla (now Shimla).

Daulet Singh was fascinated by the Ladakh Sector and rarely missed an opportunity to visit the barren and moon-like landscape, going to some of the remotest posts to get a feel of the prevailing conditions. As a result, unlike his eastern counterpart, Daulet Singh was far more rooted in reality. Not having to deal with a corps commander who only dealt with the prime minister also helped make Western Command a more cohesive organization.

Replacing Verma at the helm of XV Corps was Lieutenant General Bikram Singh. Daulet Singh had complete confidence in the 'havildar major', a sobriquet earned by the corps commander's obsession with discipline. Originally from the Frontier Force Rifles, Bikram Singh had commanded 4 Rajput and then two different brigades in Jammu and Kashmir after Partition. After two stints with Eastern Command, Bikram Singh returned to take over the JAK Division. By the time he was elevated to a three-star rank and given charge of XV Corps, Bikram Singh knew not just Kashmir, but the entire Ladakh region like the back of his hand. He had trekked to the remotest corners, be it Rezang-la, Daulat Beg Oldi, or Chip